Unit 3. Understanding 1 and 2 Timothy (Tools)

Overview

This unit develops the four steps of understanding the Bible so that they can be applied to any Bible book. The guidelines are developed and explained as they are applied to 1 Timothy. This not only gives us tools for understanding any book of the Bible, it also helps us to understand 1 Timothy. This is foundational for the module's biblical learning. Towards the end of the unit we will look briefly at 2 Timothy by comparing and contrasting it with 1 Timothy.

Outline

- Introduction: Developing the four steps
- Establishing the original CONTEXT of 1 Timothy
- Discovering the CONTENT of 1 Timothy
- Making the CONNECTIONS with our CONTEXT
- Teaching the CONTENT of 1 Timothy today
- Understanding 2 Timothy
- Conclusion

Outcomes

By the end of the unit you will be able to

1. Present the small, practical steps for understanding a book of the Bible
2. Use a set of questions to discover the setting of a Bible book
3. List the main themes of a Bible book
4. Summarise the situation and message of 1 Timothy
5. Compare and contrast 1 and 2 Timothy

3.1 INTRODUCTION: DEVELOPING THE FOUR STEPS

In Unit 2 we learnt four steps for understanding a Bible book.

FOUR STEPS FOR UNDERSTANDING A BIBLE BOOK

Step 1: Establish the original CONTEXT of the book

Step 2: Discover the CONTENT of the book

Step 3: Make the CONNECTIONS with our CONTEXT

Step 4: Teach the CONTENT of the book today

These four steps can be unpacked and then used to help us understand any Bible book in detail. This will give us a tool that we will use throughout the curriculum.

FOUR STEPS FOR UNDERSTANDING A BIBLE BOOK
Broken down into smaller steps

Step 1: Establish the original CONTEXT of the book
- Where does the book fit in the Bible's **story**?
- What **situation** was the book was written for?
- What **style** of writing was it written in?

Step 2: Discover the CONTENT of the book
- What is the **structure** of the book?
- What are the main **themes** of the book?
- What is the **message** of the book?
- What is the **purpose** of the book?

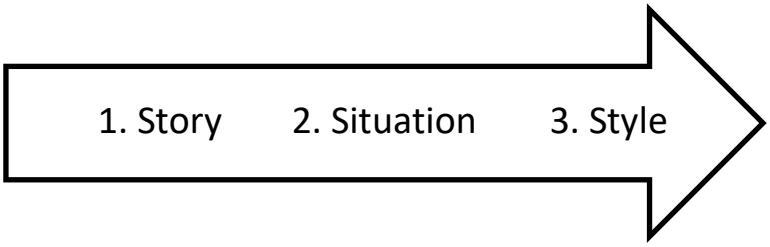
Step 3: Make the CONNECTIONS with our CONTEXT
- What **connections** are there with our situation today?

Step 4: Teach the CONTENT of the book today
- What **main points** would you make?
- How would you **raise these issues** with your listeners?

We will now learn about those detailed steps as we apply them to the book of 1 Timothy.

3.2 ESTABLISHING THE ORIGINAL CONTEXT OF 1 TIMOTHY

We will do that in three ways by looking at three different aspects of a book's context. You need to learn and remember these three words: **story**, **situation** and **style**.



3.2.1 Story

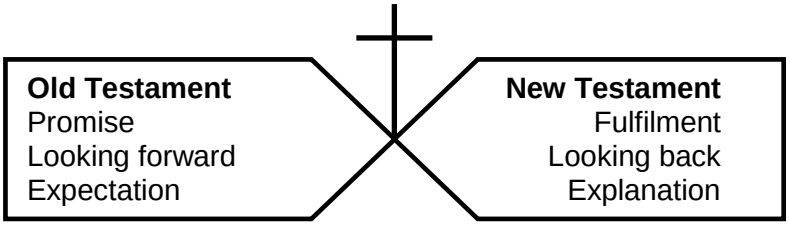
The word '**story**' here is shorthand for 'the story of the Bible'. It is very important to ask this question: Where does 1 Timothy fit into the story of the Bible as a whole? In other words, how does it fit in the development of the Bible's plot?

We will build our knowledge of the Bible's story in Module Two. Here we will introduce one simple idea: it is important to note whether the Bible passage was written before or after Jesus Christ came into the world.

In order to establish that, and what it means for understanding the passage, consider these questions:

- Is the passage in the Old Testament or New Testament?
- Is it about God's promises or the fulfilment of those promises?
- Is it looking forward to the work of Christ or looking back to what he has done.
- Is it expecting the cross and resurrection or explaining it?

This is illustrated below.



1 Timothy was written after Christ's coming. It was written in a time of fulfilment and looks back to the completed work of Christ. It is explaining the gospel and its implications for the churches. It interprets and handles the OT promises in the light of Christ.

This helps us to understand the context and the content. But it also helps us to make connections with today (see below). There may be differences between the situation of those early believers and our situation today (for example, they were still waiting for the NT to be completed whereas we have that treasure). But we have much in common. We too are in the last days, the end times after Christ's first coming and are waiting for his return. We share the same Spirit and have the same gospel. All this makes it far easier to apply the message of these letters today.

3.2.2 Situation

It is very important to discover the situation that the book was written for – its historical setting. Understanding this will bring the words and phrases to life.

Where can we find information on the setting of a letter?
Commentaries on a Bible book can be a great help, but the Bible can be adequately understood without commentaries. The most important book for understanding the Bible is the Bible. That might be a relief to you.

The fact that the Bible is able to interpret itself is based on a truth called the 'sufficiency of Scripture', which we will learn more about in Units 9 and 10. In 2 Timothy 3:15 Paul describes the Scriptures as being able "to make you wise for salvation through faith in Christ Jesus". The Scriptures, with Christ at the centre and a response of trust in him, are all we need for salvation: nothing more, nothing less.

One of the many wonderful things this means is that even though Paul's letters "contain some things that are hard to understand" (2 Peter 3:16) the Bible itself sheds light on them, particularly on the central and vital truths of our redemption. In other words:

The Bible itself provides all the information we need

to help us to understand what the Bible says about our salvation

That includes enough information on the setting of each passage of Scripture. **But how do we go about finding that information?**

Three places to find information on the Bible in the Bible

1. Other parts of the Bible shed light on the setting of a book.
The New Testament repeatedly refers to the Old Testament (for example 1 Timothy 5:18 quotes Deuteronomy 25:4). And the letters often also refer to the Gospels (for example 1 Timothy 5:18 also quotes directly from Luke 10:7). Acts often contains important background information for understanding New Testament Epistles, and that is certainly the case with the Pastoral Epistles, as we will see below.

2. Related Bible books provide useful information too.
Read the other Pastoral Epistles – 2 Timothy and Titus – for insights into the situation in 1 Timothy.

3. The Bible book itself provides the information we need.
We will look at 1 Timothy and discover the situation it was written in and for using some questions that are introduced below.

- Which parts of the Book of Acts might shed light on 1 Timothy and why? List chapters and verses. (HINT: look at 1 Tim 1:3 before turning to Acts: what place is mentioned there that also features in Acts?)

How can we use this information to establish the setting of a letter?
You need to imagine you are putting on a detective's hat, imagine that you are a policeman wanting evidence of what has been going on at the scene of 'the crime'. And you need to ask questions in order to discover the information you need. Five questions are given below:

Who? Where? What? Why? When?

- **Who** is addressing whom (which people are involved)?
- **Where** is it being written to and from (what places are involved)?
- **What** is being said (what is the main message of the book)?
- **Why** is this being said (what is the purpose of this piece of writing)?
- **When** was it written (what are the times that are involved)?

Applying these questions to 1 Timothy in order to discover the setting
Please read 1 Timothy at some point and familiarise yourself with the whole book. But as you may be learning a new skill we will focus on the beginning of the letter.

Who? Where? What? Why? When?

- **Who** is addressing whom: which **people** are involved?
  Focus on 1 Tim 1:1-7 and 1:18-20. Look, too, at 1 Tim 4:6, what does that add? Which different groups of people in the church are mentioned?

- **Where** is it being written to and from: what **places** are involved?
  Look again at 1 Tim 1:3 for where it is being written to. Are there any indications of where Paul might be?

- **What** is being said: what is the main **message**?
  Look at 1 Tim 1:3-20 and see what themes emerge. And then turn to 1 Tim 3:1-16.

- **Why** is this being said: what is the purpose of this piece of writing?
  1 Tim 1:3 and 1 Tim 3:14-15 are particularly strong on the purpose of the letter.

- **When** was it written: what are the **times** and events that are involved?
  (HINT: The important thing is to see where the book fits in the story of the New Testament and in relation to the other Pastoral Epistles. Knowing the exact date is less important, although commentaries can help with that.)

3.2.3 Style

When you read a letter from a friend, you do so in a very different way to when you read a newspaper article, or a story, or a poem.

Different Bible books – and often different parts of those Bible books – are written in different styles or genres (a technical word that means 'types of writing').

For example a letter follows a different set of rules to a poem. A story follows a different set of rules to a proverb. The style needs to be identified and kept in mind.

The Pastoral Epistles are a type of letter. There will be more on this type of writing in Unit 4 and also in Module Seven. But it is important to note that a letter is always written:

- From someone
- To someone
- With a message (or messages)
- For a purpose (or for several purposes)

Letters are **occasional**: that is they are written on a particular occasion for a particular reason. That is why it is important to discover the **situation** the letter was written for. In a letter there is an **argument** to follow: an explanation and application of Christian truth.

NOTE: In addition to the 'Who, Where, What, Why, When' questions, it is also worth asking how was it written, in other words what is the tone or feel of the writing? In other words what feelings are involved? For example, is Paul concerned or angry or encouraged? How urgent and important is the letter?

3.3 DISCOVERING THE CONTENT OF 1 TIMOTHY

We have naturally begun to discover the **content** as we have looked at the **context** above. In looking at the setting we began to see what Paul is saying to Timothy and the church in Ephesus.

Discovering the general content of a book is important before encountering particular texts. In other words, if you were preaching through a book this is a job that yields fruit for a whole series of talks.

One way to approach this is to go through the book and list the content as it comes up. Or you can note the main themes and prioritise them.

- Returning to 1 Timothy and to what we have seen so far, what is the book all about? What are the main things Paul is saying to Timothy?

3.4 MAKING THE CONNECTIONS WITH OUR CONTEXT

We have already begun to make some connections through seeing where 1 Timothy comes in the story of the Bible. We can make connections between their situation and ours. While there are differences there are similarities that we need to note.

- What are the similarities and connections between 1 Timothy and your situation and congregation, and with the world you live and work in?

3.5 TEACHING THE CONTENT OF 1 TIMOTHY TODAY

There will be more on this later in the module (Unit 13). But begin to think about how you would teach some of the content of 1 Timothy into your situation, church and churches.

- What **main points** might you make?

- How might you **raise these issues** with your listeners?

3.6 UNDERSTANDING 2 TIMOTHY

Our understanding of 1 Timothy will help us to understand 2 Timothy. We can compare and contrast the two books. They have a close relationship like two brothers.

We will do this by applying the first two steps of understanding a Bible book to 2 Timothy:

Step 1: Establish the original **context** of the book

Step 2: Discover the **content** of the book

If you have enough time together there is no better way to get to know 2 Timothy than by reading it through as a whole.

If you have limited time just look at the verses that are mentioned below, and read through the whole book later.

3.6.1 Establish the context of 2 Timothy

As you look through the book, note specific verses where you see either a similarity to 1 Timothy (something that is nearly the same), or a difference. Describe the similarity or difference by looking at the two books and moving between them. Use the space below to put down your observations. Some verses to look at have been given to help.

- What **similarities** does 2 Timothy have to 1 Timothy in terms of the context?

2 Tim 1:1-2

2 Tim 1:18

2 Tim 2:17-18

2 Tim 3:1-5

Other verses…

- What **differences** does 2 Timothy have to 1 Timothy in terms of the context?

2 Tim 1:2-5

2 Tim 1:16-17; 2:9

2 Timothy 1:15; 2:17-18

2 Tim 4:6-8; 16-18

Other verses…

3.6.2 Discover the content of 2 Timothy

As we have looked at the **context** of 2 Timothy we have begun to note the **content**. Build on that now by looking more closely at the content, the themes of the book.

- What **similarities** does 2 Timothy have to 1 Timothy in terms of the content?

2 Tim 1:6

2 Tim 1:8

2 Tim 2:22-23

2 Tim 2:1-2; 4:1-2

Other verses…

- What **differences** does 2 Timothy have to 1 Timothy in terms of the content?

2 Tim 1:13-14

2 Tim 1:8, 16; 2:3; 3:12; 4:5

2 Tim 2:9

Other verses…

3.7 CONCLUSION

We have applied the four steps of understanding the Bible that we discovered in Unit 2 to 1 and 2 Timothy.

We have discovered that in a situation where false teachers are damaging the church, the letters focus on the importance of protecting God's people and the need for true teachers of God's message, the gospel.

This message becomes more urgent and important in 2 Timothy due to the worsening situation and with Paul facing the end of his life and ministry.

Traditionally 1 Timothy, 2 Timothy and Titus have together been known as 'The Pastoral Epistles'. But that title has led to the understanding that they are letters to church leaders about the organisation and structure of their churches.

- How has this unit of teaching challenged that traditional understanding?

- What alternative title to 'The Pastoral Epistles' might best describe their purpose?